The Dissertation as Orthopraxy

Examination, Citation, and the Legal Form of Access

Pissarro, Paul-Alexander Arthur

ORCID iD 0009-0000-0830-8438

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Abstract

Scholarship registers contribution by citation. A dissertation is examined before it can be cited. What is certified at examination is therefore a forecast of contribution rather than contribution itself. This study sets that proposition against three bodies of evidence, historical, experimental and procedural, and then acts on the result.

The first is historical. The European degree ladder is a transposed craft-guild structure in which master and doctor were originally synonymous, both naming the *licentia docendi*, the licence to teach, neither certifying an original contribution to knowledge. The definition of the doctorate as certifying new knowledge is a modern retrofit, as the historiography of the German university has established: Humboldt's memorandum of 1810, the document usually credited with the research ideal, was left a fragment, went unpublished in his lifetime, and first appeared in print in 1903, and the attribution of the ideal to Humboldt is itself a twentieth-century invention. What has not been drawn from that record is its general form: a legitimating origin can be composed long after the fact, and the institution it explains runs unchanged either way.

The second is experimental. A hypnotic induction is the ritual preamble, ordinarily relaxation and fixed attention, held to produce the state in which suggestion works. When identical suggestions are administered with and without one, the induction contributes little to measured response, on the order of one and a half suggestions in ten. What governs the account the subject gives is not the procedure but its name: a conventional induction introduced as a control produces less than half the depth it produces under its own name, while white noise introduced as hypnosis produces as much as the real thing. The ceremony does not produce the capacity. It relocates its authorship.

The third is procedural. Entry to the principal scholarly indexes is conditioned on the legal form of the depositor rather than on the assessed quality of the work. The index of record for dissertations accepts them only from institutions it recognises as accredited. The principal humanities archive states that it does not publish what it hosts. The registry through which citations are counted admits organisations and not individuals, and an unaffiliated author reaches them only from inside a repository that supplies the standing they lack. The exclusion of unaffiliated scholars is well documented; what follows from it is not. A gate set on legal form rather than merit is satisfied by incorporation rather than by better work, and a gate that cheap screens for nothing it claims to screen for.

The argument is not that examination is worthless. Pre-circulation scrutiny catches error before it propagates, which no citation count can do. Rather, two functions, quality assurance and the registration of contribution, have been fused in one instrument and can be separated. Drawing on the history of the university, on artistic precedents for the self-constituted institution, on Adorno on theory as praxis, and on the performative utterance, it asks what it would mean to register a contribution without certifying it in advance. What emerges is an account of the doctorate as a forecast, and a demonstration of the alternative: a work constituted rather than petitioned, deposited under a persistent identifier, and submitted to a citation record published openly and dated before the first deposit.

Keywords

orthopraxy; credentialism; doctoral education; history of universities; Humboldt myth; suggestion and response expectancy; scholarly indexing; independent scholars; institutional repositories; open access; artistic research

How to cite this work

Cite the proposition label rather than the page. Labels are permanent and pages are not. The form is the author, the year and the label, for example **Pissarro 2026, C13**. Every proposition carries a permanent anchor on the propositions page, so C13 resolves at https://paulpissarro.com/thesis/propositions/#C13 and will continue to. A proposition later found to be wrong keeps its number and is marked withdrawn with the reason given; it is never renumbered or reused.

Propositions

Every load-bearing claim in the work, stated once and labelled permanently. A proposition marked *cite source* is somebody else's finding, restated here only so that it can be found; cite the source named beneath it. A proposition marked *cite this work* is an inference made here, and the sources beneath it are what it rests on rather than where it came from.

Band A · The historical record

Findings established by others, restated for navigation.

A1

The European degree ladder is a craft-guild structure transposed onto knowledge: bachelor, master and doctor correspond to the apprentice, journeyman and master of the medieval trades.

rashdall-1936, verger-1973 · cite source

A2

Doctoral training was formally an apprenticeship to a guild, and the customary term of study before admission to the guild of Master of Arts was seven years, matching the apprenticeship term of other medieval occupations.

rashdall-1936 · cite source

A3

Master and doctor were originally synonymous. Both named a single thing, the licentia docendi, the licence to teach.

rashdall-1936, verger-1973 · cite source

A4

Neither degree originally certified an original contribution to knowledge. Both certified admission to the body licensed to teach.

rashdall-1936, verger-1973 · cite source

A5

The licentia docendi was an ecclesiastical instrument. Papal intervention in 1179 requiring that the licence be granted to the qualified centralised authority over who might teach and, by extension, over what could be taught.

rashdall-1936 · cite source

A6

The medieval university secured a near-monopoly over a particular kind of teaching and culture. Closure was a social function of the institution, not a later corruption of it.

verger-1973 · cite source

A7

The definition of the doctorate as certifying the production of new knowledge is a modern retrofit onto a medieval licence to teach. It is not inherited from the institution's founding structure.

derived from A1 to A6; rashdall-1936, verger-1973, humboldt-1810 · cite this work

A8

Humboldt's memorandum on the organisation of the higher scientific institutions in Berlin, written in 1810 and the source usually credited with the research-university ideal, was left unfinished and was not published in his lifetime.

humboldt-1810 · cite source

A9

The memorandum was first published in 1903, in the volume of Humboldt's political writings edited by Bruno Gebhardt for the Prussian Academy of Sciences, ninety-three years after it was written. Amended October 2026: the earlier wording gave 1900 as a date of recovery, which no source supports. The claim now anchors on publication, which is documented.

humboldt-1810, verified against catalogue records · cite source

A10

The founding document of the research-university ideal became publicly available approximately a century after the institution it is credited with founding, and therefore cannot have exerted the influence attributed to it during that period. Reclassified October 2026: this inference is already established in the historiography and is no longer claimed here.

ash-2006, paletschek-2001, vom-bruch-1997 · cite source

A11

The retrospective attribution of the research-university ideal to Humboldt is itself a recognised object of scholarship, treated in the literature as the Humboldt myth.

ash-1999, ash-2006 · cite source

A12

The attribution of a legitimating origin to an institution is a general and recognised phenomenon. Traditions presented as ancient are frequently of recent origin and deliberately composed.

hobsbawm-ranger-1983 · cite source

A13

The comparison of identical suggestions given with and without an induction was first run systematically by Hull in 1933. The largest study in that line had thirteen subjects, the dependent measure was response latency on ideomotor suggestions, and subjects in the hypnosis condition had passed an additional screen that those in the waking condition had not. Hull reported that the induction facilitated responses and stated no conclusion about the magnitude of its contribution. A later recomputation of the Hull-era data reports a large effect for one 1930 study, which is the standing objection to B1. Added October 2026 to hold the historical claim that B1 previously carried.

hull-1933, juliani-mohl-2016 · cite source

Band B · The experimental record

Findings established by others, at the precision their sources support.

B1

When identical suggestions are administered with and without a hypnotic induction, the induction's contribution to measured response is small and reliably non-zero: pooled across four studies, 1.46 suggestions out of ten, standard error 0.20. Amended October 2026: the earlier wording cited Hull alone and credited him with a conclusion about magnitude that he did not state. The characterisation is Kirsch's, reading a literature that begins in 1961; the number is Martin and Dienes's. Hull ran the first version of the design, which is a historical claim and is now held at A13, together with the objection to this one.

martin-dienes-2019, kirsch-mazzoni-montgomery-2007, glass-barber-1961, barber-calverley-1964 · cite source

B2

Hypnotic and non-hypnotic suggestibility are very highly correlated, almost as highly as the scales correlate with themselves on retest, indicating that they are not distinct capacities. Reported coefficients run from 0.53 to 0.82. Amended October 2026: the phrase and the finding are the 2011 consensus statement's, not Hull's; no coefficient of Hull's own could be established.

kirsch-et-al-2011, braffman-kirsch-1999, milling-et-al-2010 · cite source

B3

Suggestions given without any induction procedure produce substantial changes in perception, memory and voluntary action.

barber-1969 · cite source

B4

Hypnotic responding is accounted for by expectancy, attitude and imaginative involvement, without requiring the postulation of an altered state of consciousness.

kirsch-lynn-1995 · cite source

B5

Placebo analgesia and symptom relief survive explicit disclosure that the agent is inert, provided the disclosure is accompanied by a plausible account of why an inert agent may work. The one trial isolating disclosure from rationale found that disclosure alone produced no effect. Pooled open-label placebo effects are moderate on self-report, 0.36 standardised mean difference, and null on objective outcomes, 0.02. Amended October 2026: the earlier wording asserted that disclosure does not abolish the mechanism, which the evidence does not support at that strength, and cited no publication. No controlled test of disclosure against concealment exists in hypnosis research; the inference from placebo to suggestion is an argument from analogy and is marked as one.

locher-et-al-2017, fendel-et-al-2025, kirsch-1996 · cite source

B6

Given the same suggestion with and without an induction, subjects report comparable perceptual effects, but report having been hypnotised only where an induction was performed, and the sense that the response was involuntary rises measurably with it. In three independent datasets the induction is inert for the outcome and not inert for the phenomenology. Amended October 2026: the earlier wording said the ceremony alters the label rather than the result, which understates its own evidence. The shift in reported involuntariness is measurable and significant.

kirsch-et-al-2008, milling-et-al-2010, kekecs-et-al-2024 · cite source

B7

A class of utterances does not describe a state of affairs but brings one into being. Naming, promising and founding are acts performed in speech rather than reports about the world.

austin-1962 · cite source

B8

Abstract concepts are structured by sensorimotor metaphor drawn from bodily experience. Reason is not separable from the body that carries it.

embodied-cognition · cite source

B9

Perception is the resolution of prediction error against prior expectation rather than the passive reception of sensory input.

predictive-processing · cite source

B10

Dopaminergic signalling encodes the difference between received and predicted reward. Salience is therefore a function of the gap between expectation and event rather than of magnitude alone.

reward-prediction-error · cite source

B11

Emotion is constructed, predicted from interoceptive signals and learned conceptual categories, rather than triggered as a fixed reaction.

constructed-emotion · cite source

B12

Aesthetic experiences rated most moving are accompanied by activation in medial prefrontal regions of the default mode network, the system associated with self-referential processing.

dmn-aesthetics · cite source

B14

The felt trance state is treated in the consensus literature as an epiphenomenon: a response to the suggestion to enter hypnosis, with no direct causal effect on other suggestions. The experience of nonvolition is not conferred by a trance but is a characteristic of response to suggestion. Markers for the hypothesised state have not been found. B13 was withdrawn before publication and its label is not reused.

kirsch-et-al-2011, lynn-et-al-2020, zahedi-lynn-sommer-2024 · cite source

B15

The induction is described in the reference literature as a feature of the hypnotic ritual, and its form does not matter: indirect wording is no more effective than standard, and a doubled induction is no more effective than a single one.

terhune-2024, martin-dienes-2019 · cite source

B16

Where the same induction is labelled hypnosis rather than relaxation, subjects are significantly more suggestible. Where subjects are told that hypnotic ability requires achieving a trance, they respond to fewer suggestions. The designation is not inert, and what the designation is taken to mean changes the outcome. Recorded October 2026; the distinction that draws on it is not yet written.

gandhi-oakley-2005, lynn-et-al-2002 · cite source

B17

In a four-condition experiment, removing the induction had no appreciable effect on any dimension of responding, while removing the references to cooperation lowered objective responding. The cooperative framing does measurable work where the ritual does not.

lynn-et-al-2002 · cite source

B18

Hypnotic responding requires the subject's active participation, and without it nothing happens. The responding is characterised in the literature as a strategic enactment shaped by the subject's understanding of the task, negotiated with the operator. This is the position of a state theorist, who also holds that for highly responsive subjects the induction procedure may be unnecessary.

kihlstrom-2008 · cite source

B19

Against B15 and B16: it is argued that the concept of an altered state should be central to any definition of hypnosis, that a relaxation procedure without the label of hypnosis is simply a relaxation procedure, and that hypnosis is therefore not reducible to suggestion. On this account the designation is constitutive rather than descriptive, and the subtraction test does not apply to it, because what remains when the ceremony is removed is a different procedure rather than the same one diminished. It is further argued that a share of hypnotic responding is social compliance rather than co-production. Recorded here because it is the strongest objection to the inferences in Band C and is held by a non-state theorist.

wagstaff-altered-state, wagstaff-1981, wagstaff-1977 · cite source

B20

Against B15: highly responsive subjects alter perception with or without an induction, with a small additional benefit from hypnosis, while subjects low in suggestibility succeed in neither condition. Suggestion without ceremony does not produce the phenomena in most people, and trait differences are not abolished by removing the ritual.

mcgeown-et-al-2012, braffman-kirsch-1999 · cite source

B21

Against the account of involuntariness in B14: an alternative theory explains the experience of nonvolition through inaccurate higher-order thoughts about intending, without expectancy carrying the explanatory load. No current theory of hypnosis commands assent, and the most recent systematic review calls for new accounts rather than ratifying an existing one.

dienes-perner-2007, zahedi-lynn-sommer-2024 · cite source

B22

Against the subtraction inferences generally: the absence of specific neural correlates is held not in itself to argue against classifying hypnosis as an altered state of consciousness.

kihlstrom-2018 · cite source

Band C · Distinctions

Inferences drawn in this work from the two records above. Each states what it serves. Nine of them support the claim in Band D; the others support the historical argument, the method, or Pillar IV. A distinction that served nothing would be a defect, not a spare part.

C1

A ceremony that can be removed without changing the capacity it is said to produce is not the cause of that capacity, whatever else its removal changes. Where a ritual is claimed to produce an effect, the test is subtraction, and the test requires naming which effect. Amended October 2026: the earlier wording said “without materially changing an outcome,” which B6 and B14 falsify. Removing the induction leaves the responding intact and removes the reported trance and part of the reported involuntariness. The ceremony does change an outcome. It does not change the capacity.

generalised from B1, B2, B3, B4, B6, B14, B15, B17, B18; contested by B19, B20, B21, B22 · cite this work · serves D1

C2

Certification is issued in advance of the use it purports to warrant. It is therefore a forecast of use rather than an instance of it, and stands in the same relation to use as a promise stands to performance.

austin-1962, structural · cite this work · serves D1

C3

A promise is a performative that can fail. Certification, being a promise about future use, inherits that liability: it can be issued correctly and still not come true.

austin-1962, derived from B7 and C2 · cite this work · serves D1

C4

Attention and citation are distinct quantities. Attention produces an audience and leaves no durable record; citation requires a persistently addressable artifact and produces a countable one. Reach is therefore not evidence of contribution under the discipline's own accounting.

structural · cite this work · serves D1

C5

Entry to the principal scholarly indexes is conditioned on the legal form of the depositor, an accredited institution, a selected publisher, or a dues-paying member organisation, rather than on the assessed quality of the work. Access is a property of legal form. The exclusion of unaffiliated scholars is not claimed here and is credited to the authors who established it.

verified against platform documentation October 2026; exclusion per elsabry-2017, tennant-2020, khanna-2022 · cite this work · serves D1

C6

A gate set on the legal form of the depositor rather than on the merit of the work is satisfied by incorporation rather than by better work. It therefore screens for the capacity to constitute an organisation, not for the quality it is held to protect, and the cost of satisfying it is a measure of what it actually selects for.

derived from C5, structural · cite this work · serves D1

C7

The doctorate's certifying function was added to an instrument designed to license teaching. Certification of contribution is a historical accretion rather than the credential's founding purpose, and cannot therefore be defended by appeal to that purpose.

derived from A1 to A7 · cite this work · serves D1

C8

A legitimating origin can be composed after the institution it explains, and the institution's operation is unchanged by its absence. An origin story is therefore subject to the same subtraction test as any other ceremony.

derived from A8 to A12 and C1 · cite this work · serves the historical argument, Band A

C9

Even where concealment adds to an effect, what it adds is purchased with the subject's ability to refuse, and that is not a permissible purchase. Disclosure is therefore required whether or not it is costless, and whatever cost it carries is the price of consent rather than a defect in the method. Amended October 2026: the earlier wording asserted that concealment adds nothing to the effect, which the evidence does not support. The argument is now ethical rather than empirical and does not depend on B5 going either way.

structural; B5 and B16 bear on the cost, not on the requirement · cite this work · serves the method, and the register the work is written in

C10

A performative utterance's effect is realised as a change in bodily state, not only as a change in belief. If concepts are structured by sensorimotor experience, perception is the resolution of prediction error, and feeling is predicted from interoceptive signal, then an utterance that alters expectation alters the body that holds it. Stated as this work's synthesis: no source named below makes this inference.

derived from B7, B8, B9, B11 · cite this work · serves Pillar IV

C11

Attention is allocated by prediction error, and material processed as self-relevant recruits the self-referential network. A work that breaks an expected pattern is therefore both more noticeable and more likely to be processed as being about its reader.

derived from B10, B12 · cite this work · serves Pillar IV

C12

The function of a legitimating ceremony is not to produce a capacity but to relocate the attribution of that capacity from the claimant to the institution. Where the ceremony is performed, the response is referred to a state the subject underwent or a warrant the institution issued; where it is absent, the same response is the claimant's own. This accounts for the position of an unaffiliated author whose work is cited, used and counted and who nonetheless holds no doctorate: the capacity is demonstrated and the attribution has nowhere to go. Stated as this work's synthesis: no source named below makes this inference. The compliance account at B19 explains the same evidence more economically and is answered in the text, not here.

derived from B6, B14, B18; contested by B19 · cite this work · serves D1

C13

A name that is constitutive of a practice is nonetheless constituted by the instances that bear it. Where the content of such a name has demonstrably been composed after the fact, an instance that satisfies the name's stated criterion participates in constituting it. The name is therefore not a gate held by an institution but an account that instances pay into. Note that B19 is a premise here and an objection at C1: that the designation is constitutive is granted, and what follows is that its content is contingent rather than that it is unassailable.

derived from A7, A12, B16, B19 · cite this work · serves D1

Band D · The claim

One proposition. It requires the two records and the seven distinctions that serve it, and nothing else.

D1

Scholarship registers contribution by citation; a dissertation is examined before it has been cited; the doctorate therefore certifies a prediction rather than a contribution.

the thesis, derived from C1 to C7, C12 and C13 · cite this work

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Generated from the propositions that cite them, in order of first use. This is not a reading list: a work earns an entry here by being cited above. A bracketed note records what about a record remains unverified.

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